Shared mailboxes: requesting access and adding to Outlook

Article KB0010068 | Owner: Messaging & Collaboration | Subcategory: Shared mailbox / calendar | Applies to: Windows 11 (23H2/24H2) laptops, macOS 14/15, Outlook for Windows (desktop), Outlook for Mac, Outlook on the web (OWA), Microsoft Teams

Summary

This article explains how to request access to an Acme Global shared mailbox, add it to Outlook (desktop or web), and resolve common issues such as the mailbox not appearing or calendar editing problems. It provides a self-help checklist for end-users and a detailed procedure for the Messaging & Collaboration service-desk team.

Symptoms

- Shared mailbox does not appear in the Outlook folder pane
- Attempting to send from the shared mailbox returns "You do not have permission to send on behalf of this user"
- Opening the shared calendar shows as read-only or you cannot create/edit meetings
- Outlook repeatedly prompts for credentials when trying to access the mailbox
- Error message: "Cannot expand the folder. The set of folders cannot be opened. You do not have permission to open this folder."

Common causes

- Full Access and/or Send As permissions have not been granted to the user
- Mailbox is not auto-mapped because the Outlook profile cache has not been refreshed
- Delegate calendar permissions are missing (user only has Reviewer instead of Editor)
- Incorrect SMTP alias or primary SMTP address used when adding the mailbox
- Permission propagation delay - changes can take up to 60?minutes to replicate in Exchange Online

Overview

Shared mailboxes at Acme Global are created in Exchange Online and managed through the Exchange Admin Center (EAC). Users must be granted Full Access (to open the mailbox) and Send As (to send mail as the mailbox address). Calendar editing requires the Delegate permission "Editor" on the shared calendar. Once permissions are granted, Outlook should auto-map the mailbox after the client synchronises with the server; if it does not appear, the user can add it manually.

Self-Help Procedure: Requesting Access and Adding Shared Mailbox

If you believe you should already have access to a shared mailbox but it is not visible, follow these steps to verify your permissions and add the mailbox manually in Outlook. This works for both Windows and macOS clients.

1. Open Outlook and navigate to **File** -> **Account Settings** -> **Account Settings**.
2. Select your Exchange account, click **Change**, then **More Settings** -> **Advanced** tab.
3. Under **These additional mailboxes are available to you:** click **Add...**.
4. Type the exact alias or primary SMTP address of the shared mailbox (e.g., "team-projects@acme.example") and click **OK**.
5. Click **Apply**, then **OK**, and close the Accounts window.
6. Restart Outlook (or wait a few minutes for the client to sync).
7. To verify calendar permissions, switch to the Calendar view, locate the shared calendar under **My Calendars**, right-click it and choose **Properties** -> **Permissions**. Ensure your name is listed with the role **Editor**; if not, request the owner or the Messaging & Collaboration team to grant Editor rights.

Service-Desk Procedure

When a ticket arrives requesting shared mailbox access or reporting that the mailbox/calendar is not usable, the Messaging & Collaboration L1 agent follows this workflow to grant the correct permissions and confirm resolution.

1. 1. **Validate the request** - confirm the user's UPN, the shared mailbox alias, and the specific permissions needed (Full Access, Send As, Calendar Editor).
2. 2. **Open the Exchange Admin Center** (https://admin.exchange.acme.example) and navigate to **Recipients** -> **Shared mailboxes**.

3. 3. Locate the target shared mailbox, click **Edit** (pencil icon).
4. 4. Under **Mailbox delegation**:
   - Add the user to **Full Access**.
   - Add the user to **Send As**.
   - Click **Save**.
5. 5. For calendar editing, still in the shared mailbox properties, select **Shared** -> **Calendar permissions**. Add the user with the role **Editor** and save.
6. 6. **Notify the user** - inform them that permissions have been granted and that Outlook should auto-map the mailbox within 15?minutes; advise a restart of Outlook if it does not appear.
7. 7. **Close the ticket** after confirming the user reports success or after waiting the standard replication window (up to 60?minutes) and verifying via a quick test login if needed.

Verification

After completing either the self-help steps or the service-desk actions, the user should perform the following checks to confirm that the shared mailbox and calendar are working correctly.

1. Open Outlook and look for the shared mailbox in the folder pane under your primary mailbox.
2. Expand the mailbox to verify you can see the Inbox, Sent Items, Drafts, etc.
3. Create a new email, set the **From** field to the shared mailbox address, and send a test message to yourself.
4. Switch to the Calendar view, locate the shared calendar, and create a new meeting invitation.
5. Save the invitation and verify it appears on the calendar with you as the organizer.
6. If any step fails, repeat the relevant procedure or contact the Service Desk again.

When to escalate

If the user reports that the shared mailbox still does not appear after permissions have been granted and Outlook has been restarted (or after waiting 60?minutes for replication), escalate to the Messaging & Collaboration senior team. Include the following details in the escalation ticket: user UPN, shared mailbox alias, timestamp of permission grant, screenshots of the Outlook folder pane showing the missing mailbox, any error messages captured, and confirmation that the user is connected to the corporate VPN or on-prem network (if applicable). If the issue appears to be a synchronization problem with Autodiscover or the offline OST file, also involve the Desktop Support team after initial Messaging & Collaboration review.

Keywords: shared mailbox, Outlook access, Send As, Full Access, calendar editor, mailbox not showing, cannot send from shared mailbox, Outlook calendar permissions, request shared mailbox, add mailbox to Outlook, Exchange Online delegation